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Dear Members of the Search Committee,

I have followed the development of the Centre on Contemporary China and the World with great interest over several years, both because of my long-standing relationship with the University of Hong Kong — including serving as the first HKU Millennium Scholar from Mainland China and later as an honorary professor in social work — and because of my long academic friendship with Professor Cheng Li dating back to our years at Berkeley.

When I learned that the Centre was recruiting postdoctoral fellows, I immediately thought of my doctoral student, Mengnan Xu, who is now completing her PhD under my supervision at Beijing Normal University. Her research agenda, methodological strengths, and long-term commitment to building original governance datasets align remarkably well with the Centre's intellectual direction and research priorities. It is therefore my great pleasure to recommend her for the Postdoctoral Fellowship at the Centre on Contemporary China and the World.

I have known Mengnan for nearly a decade, since she entered the Master of Public Management program at Beijing Normal University in 2016. Over these years, I have watched her grow from an exceptionally thoughtful graduate student into a mature and independent researcher with unusual intellectual discipline, persistence, and quiet confidence. Among the many students I have supervised during more than thirty years in academia, she stands out not simply because of her technical abilities, but because she consistently takes responsibility for difficult work that others often avoid — especially the long, patient work of building data infrastructure and making complex research possible.

Mengnan completed her Master's degree with a thesis that I considered publication-ready. Even at that stage, she demonstrated an uncommon ability to think critically and work independently. On the strength of her performance, I invited her to continue into the PhD program as my doctoral advisee. Her dissertation, a causal evaluation of China's Targeted Poverty Alleviation program using seven waves of CFPS panel data, successfully passed blind external review and is scheduled for defense in May 2026. The project combines rigorous methodological training with a deep understanding of Chinese social policy and governance processes.

What impressed me most over the years was that Mengnan never waited to be told what was missing. She had a strong instinct for identifying the underlying infrastructure a project required, and then quietly building it with remarkable persistence and care.

This quality became especially evident during the Gates Foundation China Tobacco Control initiative that I chaired — a multi-million-dollar collaborative project involving the National Health Commission, Ministry of Finance, China Taxation Administration, the Development Research Center of the State Council, non-profit organizations, and academic institutions. During this project,

Mengnan played an important role in data platform construction and cross-institutional coordination. While still a graduate student, she independently designed and built two databases — the China Tobacco Industry Watch and the China National Social Organization Database — both of which became central research infrastructure for the project. We later co-authored publications from this work, including a paper published in *BMJ Open*.

Perhaps even more importantly, this experience gave Mengnan first-hand knowledge of how China’s governance system functions in practice — how ministries coordinate, how policy implementation unfolds across institutional levels, and how state and non-state actors interact in real policy environments. As someone who has spent many years working at the intersection of academia, policy, and large-scale governance initiatives, I believe this practical understanding is an unusually important advantage. Many PhD students are trained primarily within academic settings; Mengnan developed her research perspective through direct engagement with real governance processes.

Building on this experience, Mengnan went on to construct two original databases that now form the empirical foundation of our current collaborative research. The first is a multi-actor coordination database documenting the participation of government agencies, enterprises, and social organizations in China’s poverty alleviation governance from 2010 to 2023. The second is a longitudinal database covering more than 2,000 social organizations and their funding flows and project activities. These datasets did not previously exist in the field. Their construction required not only technical skill, but also intellectual judgment — the ability to understand how institutional relationships and organizational participation shape governance outcomes over time.

These databases have become the basis for two collaborative working papers that Mengnan and I are currently developing together. One examines what we describe as a “development governance knowledge system,” highlighting forms of state-led multi-actor coordination that differ significantly from the NGO-centered frameworks common in international development research. The second develops a computational pipeline for large-scale analysis of Chinese governance documents. Both projects are now well advanced, with data collection and processing substantially completed.

As our research increasingly moved toward large-scale governance text analysis and computational methods, Mengnan also recognized the importance of gaining deeper technical experience beyond conventional academic training. At one stage of her doctoral training, she decided to spend a year working on Apple’s Intelligence platform. I strongly encouraged her to do so because I believed that the future of governance research would increasingly require scholars capable of moving fluently between social science inquiry and large-scale computational systems. What impressed me was not simply that she acquired technical experience in production-level natural language processing systems, but that she returned from the experience with a more mature understanding of how AI systems actually function under real-world conditions. This combination of empirical social science training and practical AI experience remains relatively rare, and I believe it gives her unusual long-term potential as a researcher.

This combination of institutional knowledge, empirical research experience, and computational training is precisely what makes her especially well suited for the Centre on Contemporary China and the World. Mengnan’s work speaks directly to the Centre’s research priorities. Her research on China’s poverty alleviation governance explores precisely the kinds of questions that are central to understanding state capacity, policy coordination, and institutional adaptation in contemporary China: who participates in governance, through which organizational channels, and with what forms of coordination and knowledge production. In addition, her experience working across government agencies, universities, foundations, and technology environments has given her a level of institutional

maturity uncommon among early-career scholars.

Beyond her academic accomplishments, Mengnan is thoughtful, dependable, and genuinely generous toward the people around her. She also served as a teaching assistant in my doctoral seminars, where she showed a natural ability to explain complex methodological material clearly, engage constructively with students, and support a serious learning environment — qualities I suspect her students appreciated as much as I did. Over many years of working together, I have come to value not only her intellectual ability, but also her steadiness of character. She is someone I trust deeply in collaborative work because she approaches difficult tasks with seriousness, integrity, and patience. In today's academic environment, those qualities matter enormously.

I recommend Mengnan Xu to the Centre on Contemporary China and the World with complete confidence and genuine enthusiasm. I believe she will contribute not only strong analytical and technical capabilities, but also intellectual seriousness, maturity, and a deeply collaborative spirit. I can think of few young scholars better prepared to contribute to the Centre's evolving research agenda, and I very much hope she will have the opportunity to continue her scholarly development in such an outstanding intellectual community.

Sincerely,

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